

Word family: **start / starts / started / starting / starter / restart**

Base word: start

Third-person singular: starts

Past tense: started

Past participle: started

** -ing form:** starting

Related forms: starter, restart

Useful constructions/extensions: start doing, start to do, start + noun, start something, start a business, start a machine/engine, start with, start from, start at, start as, at the start, from the start, a good/bad start, starting point, head start, false start, fresh start, start from scratch, to start with, for a start, starter, restart

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞) / related noun and verb forms (相關名詞及動詞)

Your passage contains:

> “My heart would race, my mind would go blank, and I would **start imagining the worst**.”

Here, **start** means:

to begin doing or experiencing something.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **start imagining the worst**

start means:

begin to imagine negative outcomes that were not necessarily happening yet.

The sequence is:

* you become nervous;

* your heart races;

* your mind goes blank;

* then you **begin imagining** possible disasters or failure.

Meaning: To begin doing, thinking, or experiencing something.

繁體中文: **開始進行某個動作、思考或心理活動**

中文翻譯:

> “My heart would race, my mind would go blank, and I would start imagining the worst.”

「我會心跳加速、腦袋一片空白，還會**開始想像最糟糕的情況**。」

So:

****start imagining = 開始想像****

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. ****start + -ing (開始做某事) — 開始.....****

This is the exact structure used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** To begin performing or experiencing an action.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I would ****start imagining**** the worst.”

「我會****開始想像****最糟糕的情況。」

Practice 2

> “I ****started practising**** every evening.”

「我****開始每天晚上練習****。」

Practice 3

> “She ****started feeling**** more confident after a few minutes.”

「幾分鐘後，她****開始感到****更有自信。」

****start + -ing = 某個動作、過程或狀態由沒有發生轉為開始發生****

2. ****start to + verb (開始做某事) — 開始.....****

A very important alternative construction.

Practice 4

> “I **started** once I saw a few friendly faces.”

「看到幾張友善的面孔後，我**開始放鬆下來**。」

Practice 5

> “The audience **started to ask** questions.”

「觀眾**開始提問**。」

start to do = 某個動作／狀態開始出現或進行

In many contexts:

> **start doing**

and:

> **start to do**

are both natural.

3. **start = begin an activity/process (開始活動／過程) — 開始；展開**

A broad core verb meaning.

Practice 6

> “The presentation **started** at ten o'clock.”

「簡報在十點**開始**。」

Practice 7

> “The meeting **started** with a short introduction.”

「會議以一段簡短介紹**開始**。」

start = 某項活動、事件或過程由尚未進行轉為正式進行

4. **start + noun/activity(開始某項事情) — 開始;展開**

Here **start** is transitive.

Practice 8

> “Let’s **start the meeting**.”

「我們**開始會議**吧。」

Practice 9

> “She **started the presentation** with a question.”

「她以一條問題**開始了簡報**。」

start something = 使某項活動、過程或事情開始進行

5. **start by + -ing(首先做……) — 先從……開始**

A very useful structural pattern.

Practice 10

> “I **started by writing** a simple script.”

「我**首先從寫一份簡單講稿開始**。」

Practice 11

> “She **started by thanking** the audience.”

「她**一開始先向觀眾道謝**。」

start by doing something = 把某個動作作為一連串事情中的第一步

This pattern fits your preparation section very naturally.

6. ****start with + noun**(由.....開始) — 以.....開始; 先從.....開始******

Practice 12

> “The presentation ****started with**** a short story.”

「簡報****以一個短故事開始****。」

Practice 13

> “Let’s ****start with**** the most important point.”

「我們****先從最重要的一點開始****。」

****start with something** = 把某項內容、人物或步驟放在最前面******

7. ****start from + place/point**(由某處開始) — 從.....開始******

Practice 14

> “The tour ****starts from**** the main entrance.”

「導賞團****從正門開始／出發****。」

Practice 15

> “We need to ****start from**** the basic facts.”

「我們需要****從基本事實開始****。」

****start from** = 以某個地點、階段、資料或概念作為起點******

This can be literal or figurative.

8. ****start at + time/place/level**(由某時間／程度開始) — 在.....開始; 起點為.....******

Practice 16

> “The event ****starts at**** nine.”

「活動**九點開始**。」

Practice 17

> “Prices **start at** \$50.”

「價格**由五十元起**。」

****start at = 某項活動、價格、程度等以指定的時間／數值作為起點****

Important examples:

* starts at 9:00

* prices start at \$100

* start at beginner level

9. ****start as + role/type (起初是……) — 最初以……身份開始****

Practice 18

> “She **started as** a junior employee.”

「她**最初以初級員工身份入職**。」

Practice 19

> “The company **started as** a small family business.”

「這家公司**最初是一家小型家庭企業**。」

****start as = 在某段發展歷程最初以某身份、形式或角色存在****

10. ****start = begin to exist/develop (開始存在／形成) — 開始; 形成****

Practice 20

> “The problem **started** several months ago.”

「這個問題幾個月前**開始出現**。」

Practice 21

> “The idea ****started**** as a simple experiment.”

「這個構思最初****源自／開始於****一個簡單實驗。」

****start = 某個問題、趨勢、關係或事物開始存在／發展****

11. ****start a business/company (創辦) — 開設; 創辦****

A major business meaning.

Practice 22

> “She ****started her own company****.”

「她****創辦了自己的公司****。」

Practice 23

> “They ****started a small business**** from home.”

「他們在家中****創辦了一盤小生意****。」

****start a business/company = 建立一個新的企業／商業活動並令其開始營運****

Natural Chinese is often:

* 創辦

* 開設

* 開始經營

rather than simply 「開始公司」.

12. ****start a project/programme/campaign (啟動) — 啟動; 開展****

Practice 24

> “The company ****started a new project**** last month.”

「公司上個月**開展了一個新項目**。」

Practice 25

> “The organization **started a campaign** to improve safety.”

「該機構**發起／開展了一項提升安全的活動**。」

start a project/programme/campaign = 正式使某項有組織的工作或行動開始運作

13. **start an engine/machine/device (啟動機器) — 啟動; 開動**

A genuinely distinct physical/mechanical use.

Practice 26

> “He **started the engine**.”

「他**啟動了引擎**。」

Practice 27

> “Press this button to **start the machine**.”

「按這個按鈕**啟動機器**。」

start a machine/engine = 使機器開始運作

This is not simply beginning an activity personally; it means causing a mechanism to operate.

14. **machine/engine starts (機器啟動) — 開動; 開始運轉**

The corresponding intransitive use.

Practice 28

> “The engine wouldn’t **start**.”

「引擎**無法啟動**。」

Practice 29

> “The computer ****started**** normally.”

「電腦正常****啟動****。」

****machine starts** = 機器由停止狀態轉為開始運作******

15. ****start a fire**(生火／引起火災) — 點燃; 引發******

Practice 30

> “They ****started a fire**** to keep warm.”

「他們****生火****取暖。」

Practice 31

> “The electrical fault ****started a fire****.”

「電路故障****引發了火災****。」

****start a fire** = 使火開始燃燒; 可以是故意生火, 也可以是意外引起火災******

16. ****start an argument/fight/problem**(引起) — 引發; 挑起******

A figurative causal extension.

Practice 32

> “His comment ****started an argument****.”

「他的說話****引起了一場爭論****。」

Practice 33

> “Don’t ****start a fight**** over something so small.”

「不要為這麼小的事情****挑起爭執****。」

****start an argument/fight = 使爭論、衝突或問題開始發生****

17. ****start = cause someone to begin doing something (令某人開始) — 使開始****

Practice 34

> “The question ****started me thinking****.”

「這個問題****令我開始思考****。」

Practice 35

> “The experience ****started her thinking about**** a career change.”

「這次經歷****令她開始考慮****轉換職業。」

****start someone doing/thinking = 觸發某人開始某個動作／思考過程****

18. ****a start = beginning (開始; 開端) — 開始; 開端****

Now ****start**** is a noun.

Practice 36

> “The presentation got off to a good ****start****.”

「簡報有一個很好的****開端****。」

Practice 37

> “The first few minutes are only the ****start****.”

「最初幾分鐘只是****開始****。」

****a/the start = 某件事情、過程或時期開始的部分／時間點****

19. ****at the start (在開始時) — 一開始; 開始時****

Practice 38

> “I felt extremely nervous ****at the start****.”

「我****一開始****感到非常緊張。」

Practice 39

> “The instructions were explained ****at the start**** of the session.”

「指示在課堂****開始時****已經解釋。」

****at the start** = 在某件事情剛剛開始的時候******

20. ****from the start**(從一開始) — 從一開始; 由最初起******

Practice 40

> “I was nervous ****from the start****.”

「我****從一開始****就很緊張。」

Practice 41

> “The team supported the idea ****from the start****.”

「團隊****由最初開始****就支持這個構思。」

****from the start** = 從某件事最初開始的時候起******

21. ****good/bad start**(好的／不好的開端) — 開局; 開端******

Practice 42

> “The presentation got off to a ****good start****.”

「簡報有一個****好的開局****。」

Practice 43

> “A technical problem gave the event a **bad start**.”

「技術問題令活動有一個**不好的開端**。」

a good/bad start = 某項事情最初階段表現順利／不順利

22. **starting point**(起點) — 起點; 出發點

A major compound.

Practice 44

> “Your original sentence is a good **starting point** for the discussion.”

「你的原句是一個很好的討論**起點**。」

Practice 45

> “We need a clear **starting point**.”

「我們需要一個清晰的**出發點**。」

starting point = 某個旅程、分析、討論或過程開始的位置／基礎

Literal or figurative.

23. **starting price/salary**(起始價格／薪金) — 起薪; 起價

Practice 46

> “The **starting salary** is \$40,000.”

「**起薪**是四萬元。」

Practice 47

> “The model has a **starting price** of \$500.”

「這個型號的**起價**是五百元。」

****starting + amount = 某項價格、薪酬等最初／最低的起始數值****

24. ****starting position (起始位置) — 起點位置; 初始位置****

Practice 48

> “Return the device to its ****starting position****.”

「把裝置放回****初始位置****。」

Practice 49

> “The runners moved into their ****starting positions****.”

「跑手進入各自的****起跑位置****。」

****starting position = 某項動作／比賽／系統開始前所處的位置****

25. ****head start (領先優勢) — 先行優勢; 起步優勢****

A very important fixed expression.

Practice 50

> “Practising early gave me a ****head start****.”

「提早練習令我取得了****起步優勢****。」

Practice 51

> “Experience gave her a ****head start**** over the other candidates.”

「經驗令她比其他候選人****先佔優勢****。」

****a head start = 比其他人更早開始或一開始便擁有的優勢****

26. ****false start (起步失誤／失敗的開端) — 搶跑; 不成功的開始****

This has literal and figurative uses.

A. Sport

> “The runner was penalized for a **false start**.”

「跑手因**搶跑／偷步起跑**而被處罰。」

B. Figurative

> “The project had several **false starts** before it finally succeeded.”

「項目在真正成功之前有過幾次**不成功的開端／重新開始**。」

false start = 原本似乎開始了，但因錯誤或問題而不能正常繼續的開始

27. **fresh/new start**(重新開始) — 新開始; 重新出發

Practice 52

> “The new role gave her a **fresh start**.”

「新職位給她一個**重新開始的機會**。」

Practice 53

> “After the mistake, I treated the next section as a **new start**.”

「犯錯後，我把下一部分當成一次**重新開始**。」

fresh/new start = 離開之前的問題／情況，以新的方式重新開始

28. **start from scratch**(從零開始) — 從頭開始; 由零開始

A very useful fixed expression.

Practice 54

> “We had to **start from scratch**.”

「我們不得不**從零開始／重新由頭做起**。」

Practice 55

> “I didn’t rewrite everything; I didn’t need to **start from scratch**.”

「我沒有把所有東西重寫，也不需要**完全從頭開始**。」

start from scratch = 沒有利用原有進度、成果或資源，而從最基本／零的狀態開始

29. **to start with (首先；一開始) — 首先；起初**

A very common fixed expression.

A. First point

> “**To start with**, keep your script simple.”

「**首先**，要保持講稿簡單。」

B. Initially

> “I didn’t want to do it **to start with**.”

「我**一開始**其實不想做。」

to start with = 用來引出第一點，或表示最初的情況

30. **for a start (首先；第一點) — 首先；就第一點而言**

Especially common in British English.

Practice 56

> “Why was it difficult? **For a start**, the audience was huge.”

「為甚麼這麼困難？**首先**，觀眾人數很多。」

Practice 57

> “The plan has several problems. ****For a start****, it costs too much.”

「這個計劃有幾個問題。****首先****，它太昂貴。」

****for a start = 用來提出幾個理由／問題中的第一個****

31. ****start = sudden movement caused by surprise (驚跳) — 突然一驚; 猛然一動****

A distinct, somewhat literary noun/verb sense.

Practice 58

> “She woke with a ****start****.”

「她****猛然一驚****醒了過來。」

Practice 59

> “The sudden noise made him ****start****.”

「突然的聲音令他****嚇得猛然一動****。」

****start = 因突然驚嚇或意外刺激而身體猛然一動****

This is related to ****startle****, but it is less common in everyday conversation than the “begin” sense.

32. ****with a start (猛然一驚) — 驚醒; 猛然吃驚****

Practice 60

> “He looked up ****with a start****.”

「他****猛然一驚****抬起頭來。」

Practice 61

> “She woke ****with a start**** when the phone rang.”

「電話響起時，她****猛然驚醒****。」

****with a start = 因突然而強烈的驚訝／驚嚇而突然動起來****

33. ****starter = person/thing that starts something (啟動者／啟動裝置) — 啟動器; 起始者****

A related noun with several useful senses.

Practice 62

> “The car’s ****starter**** needs replacing.”

「汽車的****起動器****需要更換。」

Practice 63

> “The official ****starter**** signaled the beginning of the race.”

「負責起跑的****發令員****發出比賽開始訊號。」

****starter = 負責使某件事情／機器開始的人或裝置****

34. ****starter = first course of a meal (前菜) — 前菜; 頭盤****

A completely different common noun meaning, especially British English.

Practice 64

> “I ordered soup as a ****starter****.”

「我點了湯作為****前菜／頭盤****。」

Practice 65

> “Would you like a ****starter**** before the main course?”

「主菜前你想吃****前菜****嗎？」

****starter = 正餐主菜之前先吃的小份菜式****

American English often uses:

> appetizer

35. **starter** = person/animal selected to begin a game/race (先發／正選) — 正選; 先發選手

Especially in sport.

Practice 66

> “He became a regular **starter** for the team.”

「他成為球隊固定的**正選／先發球員**。」

Practice 67

> “Only twelve runners were official **starters**.”

「只有十二名跑手正式**出賽／起跑**。」

starter = 在比賽／賽事一開始便正式參與的選手

36. **starter kit/pack** (入門套裝) — 入門套裝; 初學者套件

A useful compound.

Practice 68

> “The course includes a beginner’s **starter kit**.”

「課程包括一套初學者**入門套裝**。」

Practice 69

> “The software offers a free **starter plan**.”

「這款軟件提供免費的**入門方案**。」

starter + noun = 為剛開始使用／學習某樣東西的人而設的基本版本／套裝

37. **restart** = start again (重新啟動／重新開始) — 重新開始; 重啟

A major related verb.

Practice 70

> “I made a mistake but did not need to **restart** the presentation.”

「我犯了錯，但不需要把簡報**重新開始**。」

Practice 71

> “Please **restart** the computer.”

「請**重新啟動**電腦。」

restart = 在停止、失敗或中斷後再次開始某個活動／系統

38. **restart** = noun (重新開始／重啟) — 重新啟動; 重新開始

Practice 72

> “The system requires a **restart**.”

「系統需要**重新啟動**。」

Practice 73

> “The referee ordered a **restart** of the game.”

「球證下令比賽**重新開始**。」

a restart = 某個系統、活動或過程在停止後再次開始

Important distinction: **start** vs **begin**

These overlap very strongly.

start

is extremely common in everyday English and works naturally with:

- * activities;
- * machines;
- * businesses;
- * journeys;
- * processes.

****begin****

often sounds slightly more formal and is less common with some mechanical uses.

Compare:

> “The meeting ****started/began**** at nine.”

Both natural.

But:

> “Start the engine.”

very natural.

> “Begin the engine.”

✗ not natural.

So:

****start = broader everyday verb****

****begin = slightly more formal and mainly process/activity-focused****

Important distinction: ****start doing vs start to do****

Usually both are possible:

> “I started practising.”

> “I started to practise.”

Both:

「我開始練習。」

In many contexts there is little difference.

However, ****start + -ing**** is especially natural for an activity/process continuing over time.

Important distinction: **start vs open**

**start a meeting**

= make the meeting begin.

**open a meeting**

= formally begin it, often with introductory remarks/procedure.

> “The chair opened the meeting.”

= 主席宣布會議開始／主持開場。

So ****open**** can be more ceremonial/formal in meetings.

Important distinction: **start vs launch**

**start**

is broad and neutral:

> start a project

**launch**

often suggests:

* formally introduce;

* release;

* initiate publicly or strategically.

> launch a campaign

> launch a product

So:

****start a project = 開始項目****

****launch a project/campaign = 正式啟動／推出項目或活動****

Important distinction: **start a company vs run a company**

**start a company**

= create/establish it.

**run a company**

= manage/operate it after it exists.

> “She started the company in 2020 and still runs it.”

= 她 2020 年創辦公司, 現在仍在經營。

Important distinction: **start vs establish**

**start**

is everyday and broad.

**establish**

is more formal and emphasizes creating something intended to continue:

* organization;

* system;

* institution;

* relationship.

> start a company

> establish a company

Both possible, but the second is more formal.

Important distinction: **start an engine vs turn on a device**

start

is especially natural for:

* engines;

* vehicles;

* machines;

* computers/software processes.

turn on

focuses on switching electrical power on.

Compare:

> “Turn on the computer.”

= 開啟電腦電源。

> “The computer is starting.”

= 電腦正在啟動系統。

Related but not identical.

Important distinction: **start a fire vs light a fire**

light a fire

usually means deliberately ignite it.

start a fire

can mean:

1. deliberately make a fire;
2. accidentally cause a fire.

> “The fault started a fire.”

= 故障引發火災。

You cannot normally use **light** in that accidental sense.

Important distinction: **start = beginning** vs **start = cause**

Compare:

> “The meeting started.”

= 會議開始了。

versus:

> “She started the meeting.”

= 她令／主持會議開始。

The first is **intransitive**.

The second is **transitive/causative**.

Important distinction: **at the start** vs **from the start**

at the start

= at the beginning moment.

> “I was nervous at the start.”

= 一開始時我很緊張。

from the start

= beginning at the first moment and continuing from there.

> “I trusted her from the start.”

= 我從一開始就信任她。

Important distinction: **start vs starting point**

start

= the beginning generally.

starting point

= the specific initial location, fact, idea, or basis from which something develops.

> “The first paragraph is a useful starting point.”

= 第一段是一個有用的出發點。

Important distinction: **head start vs early start**

head start

= advantage over competitors because you began earlier or already have an advantage.

early start

= beginning earlier in time.

> “We made an early start.”

= 我們很早出發／開始。

> “Experience gave her a head start.”

= 經驗令她先佔優勢。

Not the same.

Important distinction: ****false start vs bad start****

****false start****

= beginning that cannot properly continue / premature start.

****bad start****

= the activity genuinely began, but the beginning went badly.

> “The runner made a false start.”

= 跑手搶跑。

> “The presentation got off to a bad start.”

= 簡報開局不順。

Important distinction: ****fresh start vs restart****

****restart****

means literally:

> start again after stopping.

****fresh start****

often has an emotional/life meaning:

> leave past problems behind and begin differently.

> “The move gave him a fresh start.”

= 搬家令他重新開始人生。

So ****fresh start**** is more figurative.

Important distinction: **start from scratch vs restart**

restart

= begin again; previous work may still remain.

start from scratch

= begin again from zero with little/no previous work retained.

> “I restarted the program.”

not necessarily lost everything.

> “I rebuilt the project from scratch.”

= 從零重做。

Important distinction: **starter vs beginner**

starter

can mean:

- * starting device;
- * first course;
- * starting player;
- * something for beginners.

beginner

specifically means:

> person who is new to an activity.

So:

> starter kit

= 入門套裝

but:

> beginner

= 初學者

Important distinction: **start** vs **startle**

These look related but should not be confused.

start

in:

> “He started when he heard the noise.”

can mean:

> suddenly move from surprise.

startle

means:

> cause someone to feel sudden surprise/fear.

> “The noise startled him.”

= 聲音嚇了他一跳。

The surprise sense of **start** is less common than ordinary **begin**.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **start** family is rich in beginning, causation, machinery, business, and fixed expressions:

* **start + -ing** = 開始做.....

* **start to + verb** = 開始.....

* **start — activity begins** = 開始

- * **start something** = 令某事開始
- * **start by + -ing** = 首先做.....
- * **start with** = 以.....開始
- * **start from** = 從.....開始
- * **start at** = 在某時間／數值開始
- * **start as** = 最初以.....身份／形式開始
- * **start to exist/develop** = 開始出現／形成
- * **start a business/company** = 創辦公司／生意
- * **start a project/campaign** = 啟動／開展
- * **start an engine/machine** = 啟動機器
- * **machine starts** = 開始運轉
- * **start a fire** = 生火／引發火災
- * **start an argument/fight** = 引發／挑起爭執
- * **a start** = 開始／開端
- * **at the start** = 在開始時
- * **from the start** = 從一開始
- * **good/bad start** = 好／差的開端
- * **starting point** = 起點／出發點
- * **starting salary/price** = 起薪／起價
- * **starting position** = 起始位置
- * **head start** = 起步優勢
- * **false start** = 搶跑／不成功的開端
- * **fresh/new start** = 新開始／重新出發
- * **start from scratch** = 從零開始
- * **to start with** = 首先／起初
- * **for a start** = 首先／第一點
- * **start — sudden movement** = 猛然一驚
- * **with a start** = 猛然驚醒／一驚
- * **starter — device/person** = 起動器／發令者
- * **starter — food** = 前菜
- * **starter — sport** = 正選／先發選手
- * **starter kit/plan** = 入門套裝／方案
- * **restart — verb** = 重新開始／重啟
- * **restart — noun** = 重新開始／重新啟動

The main semantic branches are:

> **begin**

> **cause something to begin**

> **establish/initiate something**

> **activate a machine**

> ****the beginning itself****

> ****initial advantage/position****

plus a smaller ****sudden movement from surprise**** sense.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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start + -ing	某個動作、過程或狀態由沒有發生轉為開始發生
start to + verb	開始進行、出現或經歷後面的動作／狀態
start — activity begins	某項活動、事件或過程由尚未進行轉為正式進行
start something	使某項活動、過程或事情開始進行
start by + -ing	把某個動作作為一連串事情中的第一步
start with	把某項內容、人物或步驟放在最前面開始
start from	以某個地點、階段、資料或概念作為起點
start at	以指定時間、數值、位置或程度作為起點
start as	在發展歷程最初以某身份、形式或角色存在
start — begin to exist/develop	某個問題、趨勢、關係或事物開始存在／發展
start a business/company	建立一個新的企業／商業活動並令其開始營運
start a project/campaign	正式使某項有組織的工作／行動開始運作
start an engine/machine	使機器由停止狀態轉為開始運作
machine/engine starts	機器本身開始啟動／運轉
start a fire	使火開始燃燒；生火或引發火災
start an argument/fight	使爭論、衝突或問題開始發生
a start	某件事情、過程或時期開始的部分／時間點
at the start	在某件事情剛開始的時候
from the start	從某件事情最初的時候起
good/bad start	某項事情最初階段表現順利／不順利
starting point	某個旅程、分析、討論或過程開始的位置／基礎
starting salary/price	某項薪酬／價格最初或最低的起始數值
head start	比其他人更早開始或一開始便擁有的優勢
false start	原本似乎開始，但因錯誤／問題而不能正常繼續的開始
fresh/new start	離開之前的問題／情況，以新的方式重新開始
start from scratch	不利用原有進度／成果，而從零／最基本狀態開始
to start with	用來引出第一點，或表示最初的情況
for a start	用來提出多個理由／問題中的第一個
start — sudden movement	因突然驚嚇或意外刺激而身體猛然一動
with a start	因突如其來的驚訝／驚嚇而猛然一驚
starter — machine/person	負責使某件事／機器開始的人或裝置

starter — food	主菜之前先吃的小份前菜／頭盤	
starter — sport	比賽一開始便正式參與的正選／先發選手	
starter kit/plan	為剛開始學習／使用者而設的基本入門版本	
restart	在停止、中斷或失敗後再次開始活動／系統	

For your original passage

> “My heart would race, my mind would go blank, and I would ****start imagining the worst****.”

The exact meaning is:

****start = 某個心理活動由尚未發生轉為開始發生****

Therefore:

> ****start imagining the worst****

= ****「開始想像最糟糕的情況」****

The sentence describes a sequence:

> nervousness

> → heart races

> → mind goes blank

> → ****negative imagining starts****

So the key mapping in your passage is:

****start + -ing = 開始進行某個動作／心理活動****

The most important learner contrasts are:

> ****start imagining****

> = 開始想像

> ****start to relax****

> = 開始放鬆

> ****start the meeting****

> = 令會議開始

> ****the meeting starts at nine****

> = 會議九點開始

> **start a company**

> = 創辦公司

> **start the engine**

> = 啟動引擎

> **the engine won't start**

> = 引擎無法啟動

> **start a fire**

> = 生火／引發火災

> **at the start**

> = 一開始

> **from the start**

> = 從一開始

> **starting point**

> = 起點／出發點

> **head start**

> = 起步優勢

> **false start**

> = 搶跑／失敗的開端

> **fresh start**

> = 重新開始

> **start from scratch**

> = 從零開始

> **starter**

> = 可指起動器、前菜、先發選手等

So **start** is much richer than simply:

> **start = 開始**

and in your original sentence it specifically means:

to begin experiencing a mental process — imagining negative outcomes.